The prison officials assigned a constable to accompany and deposit me at my house in Trivandrum. The constable got into the car with us. After a couple of hours into the journey, he asked me if he could get down and go home. I said yes, but he was scared that he would attract punishment if his superiors came to know that he had not accompanied me till I reached home. I said not a soul will know that he got down here. The constable thanked me profusely. I thanked him for leaving; I had had enough of the police company.

Most of the journey passed in silence occasionally broken by Sankar asking me if I wanted a tea or something. I sat blank, staring out of the window, at the passing trees and traffic. As the car reached Trivandrum, memories of the past fifty days came rushing to me. Right from the first night at the Vanchiyoor Police Station to the Latex Guest House, and the Pallipuram camp before the CBI took me to Chennai and then to the Viyyur prison in Kerala.

I realised the gravity of the case I was implicated in; I could get several years of imprisonment for violation of the Official Secrets Act, besides other penalties under the Indian Penal Code. I was not so much worried about the problems I may face in such long incarceration; suddenly my thoughts were on how my family would be without me. I had never missed my family so much as I did in the last fifty days. I also realised now that I had not been a good father or a husband. Pursuing my passion in rocket engineering, which now appeared to me as an act in selfishness, I had ignored my dear ones.

Now, a rare personal conversation with Vikram Sarabhai in August 1969 rang in my mind. Our son Sankar was born on 9 February 1969. I wanted to spend more time at home, but chose not to lose focus at work. It was the time Sarabhai was warming up to the idea of sending me to Princeton to study. In August that year I left for Princeton. While flying to the US, it so happened that Vikram Sarabhai was travelling on the same flight, Air India's *Annapoorna 707*.

Seeing me on board, Sarabhai moved from the business class to an economy seat next to mine. He was reading a book, but in between he